

Carpet Weavers, Morocco



SUMMARY

The poem's speaker describes Moroccan children sitting at a loom upon which they weave a rug depicting another world. These girls wear their black hair in oiled braids and are dressed in colorful clothes. They're all of different heights, and the image of them sitting next to each other might bring to mind a panpipe or wind chime.

The girls watch their weaving with the same rapt attention that other children might bring to watching TV. As the vision of an Islamic paradise they're weaving into this rug gets bigger, the bench they sit on will be raised up so they can reach the top of their work. At last, they will weave in the rich pink branches of the trees the rug depicts.

When the carpet is complete, the speaker imagines, a merchant will carry it away and sell it to a mosque, where people will lay it out as a prayer rug. Its thick, soft fabric will give a little bit under the weight of people's prayers.

The children, the speaker concludes, are learning through hard work over time. Through their colorful weaving, the future emerges from their fingertips and freezes into the past.

woven into something bigger than themselves. Their artwork has an important purpose in their culture and their religion: they're participating in an ancient and traditional Moroccan craft, and they're making prayer rugs, carpets that will be laid down in a "mosque" and used in some of Islam's most sacred daily rituals.

For that matter, the actual act of weaving works as an image of the way the girls are connected to their culture and to the divine. Just as a weaving brings many disparate threads together into one beautiful picture, the girls' artistry makes them part of the tapestry of Moroccan culture.

In this poem, then, the act of weaving [symbolizes](#) the work it takes to connect with something bigger than oneself. Through their dedication to their craft, the poem suggests, these girls find a place in a harmonious network of tradition and belief.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-12



CULTURAL DIFFERENCE, CURIOSITY, AND RESPECT

The speaker of "Carpet Weavers, Morocco" is an outsider, a traveler watching young Moroccan weavers at their loom. At a few moments, the poem hints that some aspects of this sight might be shocking to the speaker: for instance, the fact that these mere "children" work this difficult job can't help but feel surprising (and perhaps worrying) to an outsider who comes from a place where child labor isn't legal. But the speaker's persistent curiosity and respect in spite of this surprise suggests that cultural difference needn't be a source of division; instead, it can be an opportunity to question one's own cultural assumptions and values.

Watching the young weavers at their work, the speaker is impressed by their elegance and skill. With their lovingly "oiled" braids and "bright" dresses, the girls "make a melodious chime" on the eye, and the rug they're weaving is absolutely beautiful, a demonstration of astonishing skill for children these girls' age. These are clearly young people who take themselves and their work seriously, and who play an important part in their culture: they're working at a traditional craft with an important religious purpose. (Their weavings, the speaker knows, will be used as prayer rugs in mosques.)

But by the same token, the weavers' seriousness is a little startling to the speaker. When the speaker observes that the girls "watch their flickering knots like television," they subtly reveal what they're more used to watching children doing: zoning out in front of the TV. To an observer from a country



THEMES



ARTISTRY, CONNECTION, AND THE SACRED

In "Carpet Weavers, Morocco," a speaker looks on a group of young Moroccan girls weaving prayer rugs and sees something sacred in their hard daily work. Deeply committed to their weaving—and deeply connected to religious and cultural traditions *through* their weaving—these girls make something holy out of an intense job. Artistry and craft, the poem suggests, can be sacred rituals that weave craftspeople into the world around them.

The young weavers, the speaker observes, are deeply focused on their traditional craft, watching their "flickering knots" with the same hypnotized attention that a Western kid might bring to a flickering "television." The girls' commitment to their task also shows in their "varied heights," which remind readers that these kids start their work very young and keep doing it all through their childhoods. To become an expert weaver, in other words, takes serious commitment and sacrifice (of a kind that might seem shocking to someone from a culture in which children aren't legally allowed to work!).

But the girls' commitment to their art form, the speaker reflects, might also reward them with a sense that they are

where children don't work, the sight of kids with jobs can't help but raise a certain unease.

However, the speaker's remark about television might also hint at their ambivalence about their own culture. Rather than passively watching TV, the young weavers are engaging in an important task that they can feel pride in, and one that connects them to their culture and their religion.

Instead of reacting with pure shock and disapproval to the young carpet weavers, then, the speaker uses the difference between these girls' culture and their own to reflect on both of these worlds. Doing so allows them to see the deep beauty in what the girls are doing. The young weavers' care, their skill, and their deep connection with their cultural traditions all stand out more brightly precisely because their world is different from the one the speaker knows.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-12



LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

LINES 1-3

*The children are ...
... a melodious chime.*

As "Carpet Weavers, Morocco" begins, the poem's speaker watches a group of "children" as they sit at their "loom." These are the "Carpet Weavers" of the title, a surprisingly young group of workers—even a *startlingly* young group of workers, if one is an outside observer from a place where children don't work. And this speaker, readers soon gather, must be just such an observer. Even the poem's title—"Carpet Weavers, Morocco"—suggests an outsider's eye. This isn't the perspective of someone who lives in this place and knows these particular girls, but the alert, curious perspective of a visitor seeing something they haven't seen before.

Though the image of children at work might be startling to the speaker, the picture here isn't one of grueling child labor, but of magic and beauty. For these "children," the speaker says, "are at the loom of another world."

That [metaphor](#) invites a sense of the sacred and the strange into the poem right from the get-go. On one level, this vision might simply describe the image the children are weaving into the carpet they're working on: the carpet might *depict* another world, an enchanted garden or a forest. But there's also a hint of something deeper here. The children's weaving, this mysterious turn of phrase suggests, might connect them with "another world," with a spiritual world beyond our own. The word "loom," which can be a verb meaning "to tower over" as well as a noun meaning "a weaving frame," deepens that sense

of mystery. Even as they toil at a literal loom, these children might be sitting in the shadow of something divine.

The speaker doesn't dig deeper into this potent idea—at least, not right away. Instead, they turn their attention to the weavers themselves, using moments of bright [imagery](#) to show readers a group of neat, bright, healthy children. These little girls' "braids are oiled and black," the speaker notes; these dark braids stand out against "bright" dresses. The young weavers are carefully dressed and lovingly groomed.

In fact, they're generally lovely to look at. Even their "assorted heights" as they sit in a row would "make a melodious chime," the speaker says. That is, they remind the speaker of a panpipe or wind chime. This moment of synesthesia, linking sight to sound, suggests that there's something pleasing as music in the vision of these girls at their work. (The musical [alliteration](#) on the /br/ sound of "braids" and "bright" and the [assonance](#) on the /i/ sound of "bright," "heights," and "chime" helps create that effect, too.) But again, that image might invite a note of outsider's discomfort into the poem. If the girls are all different heights, they must start at this work when they're very young—and keep on doing it all through their childhoods.

In just these first three lines, then, the poem mingles beauty, alarm, fascination, and curiosity. The speaker notices these girls because, at first, they're startled by them. But as the speaker goes on looking, they see more and more loveliness in what might at first merely look alien.

LINES 4-6

*They watch their ...
... of the tree-tops.*

As they sit at their work, the speaker goes on, the girls "watch their flickering knots like television." Here, readers again get a glimpse of what the speaker might be more used to seeing children doing: slouching in front of a "flickering" TV.

While again revealing the speaker's surprise at the sight of these laboring children, this [simile](#) also introduces a note of ambivalence about the speaker's own culture. Watching TV might give European kids the same hypnotized expression that these girls wear. But theirs is a *passive* hypnotism, and one that doesn't necessarily hold much inherent meaning. These girls, on the other hand, are working at a craft, doing something creative.

That sense of meaning becomes even stronger as the speaker describes exactly what the girls are up to. They're weaving a "garden of Islam" into this rug—a botanical pattern meant to evoke an Islamic vision of Paradise. This carpet, then, has significance. It's not just some throwaway accessory, it's a meaningful work of religious art. For that matter, it has *cultural* significance: carpet weaving is an ancient Moroccan craft. In working on this rug, the girls are practicing an impressive skill; they're also deeply involved in their culture.

A meaningful ambiguity in the poem's language deepens that idea. Look closely at lines 5-6:

As the garden of Islam grows, the bench will be raised.
Then they will lace the dark-rose veins of the tree-tops.

Just as in the first line's "loom of another world," there's a potential double meaning here:

- On the one hand, this is a simple description of the process of weaving the rug. As the rug gets bigger, the bench the girls sit on will have to be raised so they can comfortably reach their work.
- On the other, the "garden of Islam" might be read as a [metaphor](#) for the girls themselves: the flowers of their culture, growing up. Their bench will have to be raised as *they* get bigger, too!

The [imagery](#) of the girls "lac[ing] the dark-rose veins of the tree-tops" into their carpet—besides painting a lovely picture of the delicate, intricate, richly pink branches the girls weave—invites readers to think about the girls' *literal* veins and the blood that runs in them. These children are physically, spiritually, and culturally woven *into* their work.

LINES 7-9

*The carpet will ...
... heaped with prayer.*

Now, the speaker looks up and away from the loom and into their own imagination, picturing what will happen to the carpet when the girls have completed it. It will go on a journey, they think: it will "travel in the merchant's truck" and make its way to a "mosque," where it will be "spread by the servants" who care for this sacred place. When the carpet is unrolled on the mosque's floor, its "deep and soft" fabric will "give when heaped with prayer."

The weavers are not making just any rugs, then, but *prayer* rugs, carpets that will be used in the daily prayers that are a cornerstone of Islam. Their work is an important part of the *fabric* of their society, one might say.

The [metaphor](#) of the rug "heaped with prayer" presents prayer as a physical object, something heavy and substantial that needs to be cushioned. Here, the girls' rugs accommodate something spiritually *weighty*. These lines again stress the cultural importance of these girls' work.

And there's yet another potential [pun](#) in this image. To "give" may mean to "yield beneath": the prayer rug is imagined here as soft and plush, offering generous comfort. But to "give" may also be to *offer* something. The girls' work connects them to their religion and their culture by *giving back* to that culture.

Perhaps their weaving is itself a kind of prayer, then, a meditative devotional activity that connects them to something greater than themselves.

Here, readers might want to pause and consider the way the poem's *shape* reflects the girls' meticulous craft. While this poem is written in [free verse](#), without a regular [rhyme scheme](#) or meter, its form is anything but loosey-goosey. The stanzas all use three lines of roughly equal length—and, so far, every one of those lines has been [end-stopped](#) with a firm period. The poem's shape—regular, rectangular, steady, even, with each line neatly tied off—thus resembles nothing so much as a woven rug! Rumens's regular, disciplined poetic craft mirrors the careful artistry her speaker describes.

LINES 10-12

*The children are ...
... frame of all-that-was.*

As the final stanza begins, the speaker hearkens back to the poem's first line. The first stanza began with the words, "**The children are** at the loom of another world"; the final stanza begins with the words "**The children are** hard at work in the school of days." This moment of [anaphora](#) draws a parallel between sitting at the "loom of another world" and being "hard at work in the school of days." To approach the other world of the sacred, the [repetition](#) suggests, takes daily discipline, time, and labor.

And once again, the kind of labor involved here feels foreign to the speaker. The [metaphor](#) of the "school of days" might again raise a comparison with the TV-watching kids the speaker seems more familiar with, who spend their days at a literal school, not sitting at a workbench. But as the speaker has shown, these young Moroccan girls' difficult working lives weave them into their culture and their religion, connecting them to their wider world just as the threads of their weaving connect to form a bigger picture. The weavers' childhoods may look different than those of children elsewhere in the world. But their lives are full of pride, connection, and significance.

The poem's closing metaphors reveal that the girls' work connects them to the sacred in more mysterious ways, too:

*From their fingers the colours of all-that-will-be fly
and freeze into the frame of all-that-was.*

Under the girls' hands, in other words, the metaphorical fabric of the future "fl[ies]" out and "freeze[s]" into the "frame" of "all-that-was": of tradition, of the past. In this image, the girls are pouring their own futures, their "all-that-will-be," into the carpets they weave. (A "frame" is another word for a loom.) On the one hand, this is a sacrifice: they're giving their childhoods to this work. On the other, it's a transformation. Through their weaving, the girls make themselves part of something lasting. The beautiful rugs they weave may well outlive them, enduring

into the years when they, too, have become part of “all-that-was,” of the past. They’re also part of the “frame of all-that-was,” part of an ancient traditional structure of craft and of prayer.

It’s no coincidence that the poem’s single [enjambment](#) appears here, linking its last two lines (“fly / and freeze”). That enjambment provides a sense of continuity, mirroring the unbroken thread of tradition that connects the girls to their work.

In the eyes of this poem’s fascinated speaker, these weavers’ work demands a lot from them. But it also gives something important back. The richness and beauty of that balance might not have been evident to a speaker so shocked by the sight of child labor tht they couldn’t bear to keep looking. Alongside its respect for craft and tradition, this poem displays a respect for cultures other than the speaker’s own—an attitude of openness and curiosity.



SYMBOLS



WEAVING

In “Carpet Weavers, Morocco,” the act of weaving becomes a [symbol](#) of the way that artwork and craft can connect people to their culture and to the divine. Through weaving, the little girls sitting at the loom are making separate things into one thing, turning loose threads into a coherent picture. The fact that the particular picture they’re working on is a prayer rug depicting the “garden of Islam”—the Islamic vision of paradise—invites readers to draw a symbolic connection between the act of weaving and the act of prayer, practices that work in similar ways.

Both weaving and prayer are repetitive, rhythmic, dedicated efforts to make a *connection*: between threads in weaving, between the human and the divine in prayer. And both of these activities have something to do with small efforts adding up to part of a bigger picture. Through their laborious work, the poem suggests, the girls reach out to “another world,” touching something sacred. Similarly, weaving connects the girls to their cultural traditions: carpet-making is an ancient and revered Moroccan craft. The girls’ weaving thus comes to symbolize a lovely, life-giving kind of interconnection.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- Line 1
- Lines 4-6
- Lines 10-12



POETIC DEVICES

IMAGERY

The poem’s [imagery](#) captures the loveliness of the young weavers at their work. When the speaker first looks at the girls sitting at the loom, they notice the care and beauty with which these young women present themselves as much as the rug they’re working on. The girls’ “braids are oiled and black,” the speaker observes, and their dresses are “bright”: an image in which the girls’ dark, shining, lovingly maintained hair stands out against lively color. These girls (or their parents!) clearly bring the same meticulous attention to their hair and clothes that they do to their work.

While that first image suggests there’s a similarity between the girls (all with the same oiled braids and bright dresses), another notes the variation between them. “Their assorted heights,” the speaker says, “would make a melodious chime.” Linking sight to sound, this moment of synesthesia suggests just how harmonious the girls look together: all different heights, they’re pleasing to the eye as a major chord would be to the ear. This image also reminds readers that these children may be dedicated to this work for life: the tallest girl in the “chime” now might have started weaving when she was as little as the shortest.

The weaving grows, too. Eventually, when this rug is nearly done, the girls will reach up to “lace the dark rose-veins of the tree-tops,” the speaker imagines. This image gives readers a flash of the rug’s colors and imagery: trees woven in a deep pink wool, their delicate branches reaching out in patterns like veins. (Perhaps the [metaphor](#) of the veins also reminds readers that the girls are figuratively pouring their life’s blood into this work.)

The speaker later imagines where this rosy rug will go when it’s finished. It will end up in a “mosque,” where, “deep and soft, it will give when heaped with prayer.” Readers might be able to feel the plushness of the rug beneath their own knees at this line: the imagined “give” of the fabric suggests a thick, luxurious, generous surface.

Together, these images capture the speaker’s impression of sacred loveliness in the weavers and the weaving. These girls, young though they are, demonstrate the holiness of care, skill, and beauty through their bodies and their work alike.

Where Imagery appears in the poem:

- **Lines 2-3:** “Their braids are oiled and black, their dresses bright. / Their assorted heights would make a melodious chime.”
- **Line 4:** “their flickering knots”
- **Line 9:** “Deep and soft, it will give when heaped with prayer.”

METAPHOR

"Carpet Weavers, Morocco" is thick with mysterious [metaphors](#). The speaker's figurative language helps readers understand that the girls at the loom are doing something more than just a job as they weave their rugs. This mood of significance comes through in the very first line: "The children are at the loom of another world." Here, the carpet the children weave becomes a completely new *place*, one that already seems as if it might be sacred. When people talk about "another world," they're often thinking of a heavenly one; the rug the kids are weaving here seems as if it might be both show a picture of paradise and become the door that might let them in.

That sense of connection between the children's craft, their daily lives, and their spiritual lives becomes clearer in the second stanza, where the speaker observes: "As the garden of Islam grows, the bench will be raised." This complex metaphor interweaves the girls themselves and the rugs they work on:

- On the more obvious level, the "garden of Islam" is the beautiful botanical picture that the girls are weaving into the rug, one which will someday depict the "tree-tops" of an Islamic vision of paradise. The bench they sit on will have to be "raised" as the rug comes closer to completion so they can reach the branches at the highest point of the weaving.
- More mysteriously, though, the girls themselves might also be the "garden of Islam" here: the metaphorical flowers of their religious culture. In this reading, the bench will have to be raised as *they* grow and their legs get too long for their kid-height seating arrangements.

These children's bodies and spirits are thus shown to be *interwoven* here. And that's one of the poem's biggest points! Weaving is the poem's quiet, overarching [extended metaphor](#). Through the image of the young weavers, Rumens suggests that artistry, spirituality, culture, and one's own small life might all be brought together by the kind of craft that serves a bigger purpose.

In this case, the rugs don't just depict an Islamic image, they play a role in Islamic ritual: when they're complete, the speaker notes, they'll go on to serve as prayer rugs in a mosque. The rugs' soft fabric, the speaker imagines, will "give when heaped with prayer." Here, the speaker pictures prayer as a substance with weight and mass (while also raising the image of people bowing in prayer on these soft rugs). Again, the spiritual and the physical intertwine. (There might be a meaningful [pun](#) here, too: the rugs will give under the weight, but they'll also *give* something to those who pray on them: their beauty, their care.)

A final complex metaphor arises in the last stanza, when the speaker describes the children "hard at work in the school of days." In this image, simply living through the "days" of one's life

is like attending a school. Part of that schooling involves an understanding of how time itself works—something that these girls, with their laborious, patient craft, have a particularly acute sense of. As the speaker puts it:

From their fingers the colours of all-that-will-be fly
and freeze into the frame of all-that-was.

In this metaphor, the "colours" with which the girls weave—the threads of their rug—touch the future, "all-that-will-be," by preserving a moment of the past, "all-that-was." Pouring their care into their craft, the girls *preserve* that sacred attention in a form that will allow the people of the future, kneeling to prayer on this rug, to feel it too.

Where Metaphor appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** "The children are at the loom of another world."
- **Line 5:** "As the garden of Islam grows, the bench will be raised."
- **Line 9:** "Deep and soft, it will give when heaped with prayer."
- **Lines 10-12:** "The children are hard at work in the school of days. / From their fingers the colours of all-that-will-be fly / and freeze into the frame of all-that-was."

SIMILE

A single [simile](#) helps to give readers a hint of the speaker's identity, revealing the outsider's perspective they bring to the scene of little girls weaving carpets. This simile arrives in line 4, where the speaker describes how the girls "watch their flickering knots like television." These words imply a comparison between two very different kinds of childhoods. While some kids—the kinds of kids the speaker is more familiar with—spend their time watching TV, *these* kids have jobs. And they bring to those jobs the same kind of rapt, hypnotized attention that a kid from a different culture might bring to Saturday morning cartoons.

While the rest of the poem makes it clear the speaker feels deep respect, even awe, for these little girls' artistry, the image of kids watching TV also introduces a note of discomfort. For a person who's used to seeing kids enjoying themselves, it might be disturbing to watch small children working demanding day jobs. There's a subtle reminder of cultural difference here, a squirm of unease at the sight of child labor.

By the same token, though, a person who is used to seeing kids' mouths hanging open in front of a screen might feel a little uncomfortable at their own culture's passivity. These weavers seem deeply engaged with their work, and their work has cultural meaning and value for them: the rugs they weave will pad the floors of mosques and play a sacred role in daily prayer.

Perhaps it's most accurate to say, then, that this simile reveals

the speaker's *ambivalence* at the sight of the young carpet weavers. These kids are watching their loom, not the TV—and to this speaker, that's both a disquieting and a beautiful thing.

Where Simile appears in the poem:

- **Line 4:** "They watch their flickering knots like television."

END-STOPPED LINE

Nearly every single line in this poem is neatly [end-stopped](#). All of the lines but one come to firm, separate conclusions marked by periods. The first stanza provides a good example:

The children are at the loom of another world.
Their braids are oiled and black, their dresses bright.
Their assorted heights would make a melodious chime.

These firm statements help the poem to match what it's describing: the steady, rhythmic process of weaving a rug. Each line feels like a new row of a carpet's weft threads (that is, the crosswise horizontal threads that get woven through the stationary, vertical warp threads). And like those weft threads, each contained, individual line helps the poem to build up toward its bigger picture.

Only in one spot is there a little flicker of variation in the poem's steady end-stopped rhythm. Take a look at lines 11-12:

From their fingers the colours of all-that-will-be fly
and freeze into the frame of all-that-was.

This single [enjambment](#) lifts this image of colors "fly[ing]" off the page, suggesting that the little girls' work has something potentially transcendent about it. Through their steady weaving, they create art that will outlast them, capturing "all-that-was" in carpets that will head out into the world of "all-that-will-be."

Where End-Stopped Line appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** "world."
- **Line 2:** "bright."
- **Line 3:** "chime."
- **Line 4:** "television."
- **Line 5:** "raised."
- **Line 6:** "tree-tops."
- **Line 7:** "truck."
- **Line 8:** "mosque."
- **Line 9:** "prayer."
- **Line 10:** "days."

ALLITERATION

In line 3, the speaker describes the pleasing effect of girls of all

ages and sizes sitting together at the loom: "their assorted heights would make a melodious chime," they observe. Much feels melodious here: musical "chime[s]" of [alliteration](#) arise all through the poem, supporting the speaker's impression of the weavers' harmony and beauty.

Line 2, for instance, in which the speaker describes the girls, strings together alliterative sounds like beads:

Their braids are oiled and black, their dresses bright.

Here, bold /br/ sounds make the "braids" seem to stand out even more clearly against the "bright" dresses. The related /b/ sound in "black" makes the whole line feel harmonious.

Lines 8-9 use alliterative [sibilance](#) to capture the texture of plush carpets:

It will be spread by the servants of the mosque.
Deep and soft, [...]

All those /s/ sounds (supported by the internal sibilance of "servants" and "mosque") feel as soft and padded as the rugs the lines describe.

And in lines 11-12, the poem concludes on a flurry of /f/ alliteration:

From their fingers the colours of all-that-will-be fly
and freeze into the frame of all-that-was.

Soft, light /f/ sounds and scratchier /fr/ sounds might here evoke the actual sounds of loom weaving: the soft pull of thread against thread and the friction of the shuttle.

Where Alliteration appears in the poem:

- **Line 2:** "braids," "black," "bright"
- **Line 3:** "make," "melodious"
- **Line 5:** "garden," "grows"
- **Line 7:** "travel," "truck"
- **Line 8:** "spread," "servants"
- **Line 9:** "soft"
- **Line 11:** "From," "fingers," "fly"
- **Line 12:** "freeze," "frame"



VOCABULARY

A melodious chime (Line 3) - A pleasant-sounding harmony.

The garden of Islam (Line 5) - The speaker here refers to the beautiful botanical pattern being woven into this rug (which will be used for Islamic prayers). The garden is a common [symbol](#) for Paradise in Islamic tradition.

Mosque (Line 8) - An Islamic place of worship where the

Muslim faithful kneel on rugs to conduct their daily prayers.

The school of days (Line 10) - A [metaphor](#) for the kind of learning that takes place through time and experience (rather than formal schooling).



FORM, METER, & RHYME

FORM

"Carpet Weavers, Morocco" is written in [free verse](#). That means that it doesn't use a regular [rhyme scheme](#), [meter](#), or poetic form. Instead, Rumens invents her own meaningful form, shaping the poem to match (and to honor) the scene she describes.

Rumens divides the poem's twelve lines—which are all of roughly equal length—into four three-line stanzas (a.k.a. tercets). On the page, the poem looks regular, steady, and rectangular: in short, it looks a lot like the carpet the little weavers are working away on. The poem thus feels as meticulously and meditatively *crafted* as the sacred carpet is, steadily woven right alongside the "garden of Islam" growing in the carpet's threads.

Besides simply fitting the poem to the scene that it describes, this form subtly draws a connection between the literal kind of weaving the children are doing and the [metaphorical](#) kind of weaving Rumens is doing. Poetry and carpet-weaving, this form suggests, are both ways to use art as a kind of sacred meditation, and perhaps to reach out to the future through the work of one's hands and mind.

METER

Written in [free verse](#), "Carpet Weavers, Morocco" doesn't use a regular [meter](#). Nonetheless, the poem looks and feels *even*. Its lines are all about the same length, and its stanzas move in steady groups of three lines apiece. The poem's form ends up resembling nothing so much as the carpet the little weavers are working on, mirroring both the shape of their artwork (regular and rectangular) and the pace at which they work (measured and rhythmic).

[End-stopped lines](#) play a big part in creating the steady rhythm here. Nearly every line in the poem ends with a firm period, so the stanzas move along slowly and deliberately. The only exception to this rule arrives in the poem's final lines, where a single [enjambment](#) appears:

From their fingers the colours of all-that-will-be fly
and freeze into the frame of all-that-was.

Landing on the word "fly," that enjambment helps to launch into the poem's final mysterious images with extra energy, matching the creative leap across time that the lines describe.

RHYME SCHEME

This poem is written in [free verse](#), so it doesn't use a regular [rhyme scheme](#). Instead, it creates music through flickers of [internal rhyme](#), as well as broader [assonance](#) and [alliteration](#).

Lines 2-3, for instance, knit sounds together as the carpet weavers intertwine their threads:

Their braids are oiled and black, their dresses bright.
Their assorted heights would make a melodious chime.

Most striking here is the internal rhyme between "bright" and "heights." The long /i/ sound in both of those words also links to the [metaphorical](#) "chime" these little girls' varied heights make in the speaker's eye. The striking /br/ alliteration of "braids" and "bright" and the softer /m/ alliteration of "make" and "melodious" deepens the texture of the sounds here. All these effects work together to make the poem's music match what it describes: a scene of collaborative artistic harmony.

Sonic devices do this kind of atmospheric work all through the poem. For instance, when (in lines 8-9) the speaker describes the completed carpets finding a home at a mosque, [sibilant](#) /s/ sounds capture mood and sensation alike:

It will be spread by the servants of the mosque.
Deep and soft, it will give when heaped with prayer.

This plush sibilance suggests the softness of the carpets and the hush of the mosque alike.



SPEAKER

The poem's speaker doesn't reveal much about their identity. Instead, they're fully focused on the titular "Carpet Weavers." The speaker's delicate, careful attention to the children parallels the children's delicate, careful attention to the rug they're working on.

There are hints, though, that the speaker may be a voice for the poet herself, or at least for someone whose cultural background is more like Carol Rumens's than the children's. When the speaker observes, for instance, that the children "watch their flickering knots like television," they imply a comparison with what English children (for example) might be more likely to spend their time doing. For that matter, the speaker's very fascination with the carpet weavers might suggest that they're seeing them from the perspective of someone who doesn't watch children doing this kind of work every day.

But really, readers can gather more about the speaker from the poem's tone than anything. This speaker is clearly a thoughtful person, sensitive to the beauty and significance of the

children's craft and moved by the thought that the carpets they weave will serve a sacred purpose—and perhaps outlast their creators, living on as a token of “all-that-was.”



SETTING

As the title informs readers, this poem takes place somewhere in Morocco. There's no more specific location given than that. Readers might thus get the sense that the speaker is a traveler in Morocco, not a native: the poem feels as if it captures not a local's familiarity with an everyday sight in a particular town, but a general impression of a whole country, anchored in one [symbolic](#) scene.

That scene is the sight of a group of young carpet weavers seated in front of a loom. The speaker looks at these little girls with alert fascination, noticing their “bright” dresses and shining, “oiled” braids. Most particularly, they notice the girls' careful, expert attention to their work.

Observing that the girls “watch their flickering knots like television,” the speaker suggests that there's something *different* about these girls' lives than the lives of the children they know. During a time of life when European kids might be watching TV, these girls are “hard at work”—something that might seem shocking to someone from a country where child labor is outlawed. But by the same token, these girls are real craftswomen, deeply engaged with an art that has spiritual and cultural value to them. The rugs here will be taken to a “mosque” one day and “heaped with prayer,” used in Islam's sacred daily rituals.

The poem's cultural setting is thus revealed through a sense of difference. The speaker feels deep respect for these girls in their “harmonious” and beautiful work. That respect is only deepened by their sense that other children live differently. As the speaker says in the first line, these children sit at the “loom of another world”; to this speaker, that other world is both Morocco and the world of the divine.



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

Carol Rumens (1944-present) is a contemporary British poet. She published her first collection, *A Strange Girl in Bright Colours*, in 1973, and has published 15 further books of poetry since. “Carpet Weavers, Morocco” was first collected in her 1987 book *Selected Poems*. Alongside her career as a poet, she has worked as a translator, a professor of creative writing, and a journalist. Her “[Poem of the Week](#)” column, in which she chooses a weekly poem to examine and admire, runs in *The Guardian*.

Of her work, [Rumens once said](#):

Am I a poet? I hope so but how can I be sure? I would rather describe myself simply as someone who loves language, and who tries to make various things with it—poems, chiefly, but also essays, plays, translation, occasional fiction and journalistic odds and ends. Poetry can sometimes bring these different genres interestingly together.

Rumens mentions the English poet [Philip Larkin](#) as an important early influence. But her extensive travels in Russia, Ireland, and Eastern Europe mean she also counts international writers like the Russian [Anna Akhmatova](#) and [Osip Mandelstam](#) and the Irish [Paul Muldoon](#) and [Medbh McGuckian](#) among the poets important to her.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Carol Rumens published this poem in 1987, the same year that Morocco applied to become a member of the European Communities (an alliance that would later evolve into the European Union). The country's application was declined on the basis that Morocco wasn't part of the European continent. But the attempt reveals something about the complex relationship between Morocco and Europe.

This poem's speaker sees Morocco as interestingly (and perhaps startlingly) different from the world they know (which, readers can guess, might be Rumens's native UK). But Morocco has a long history of cultural exchange with Europe and with Spain in particular. Separated only by the Strait of Gibraltar (a narrow sea passage), Spain and Morocco have alternately warred and allied themselves for hundreds of years. The two countries' rich history of trade means that Moroccan and Spanish art and architecture each show the marks of the other culture.

Perhaps Morocco is an especially potent setting for this poem precisely because it is a place of cultural meeting and exchange. Carol Rumens, who has traveled widely and spent time living in several foreign countries, might have felt an appreciation for Morocco's paradoxical combination of closeness to and distance from the culture she was born into.



MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [Rumens's Website](#) — Learn more about Rumens on her personal website. (<https://www.carolrumens.co.uk/index.shtml>)
- [Morocco's Weavers](#) — Watch a short video about Moroccan carpet weaving and learn more about weaving's honored place in Moroccan culture. (<https://youtu.be/AygUx4SPfxA?si=tmjBLV0VvNZvf0jZ>)
- [A Brief Biography](#) — Learn more about Rumens's life and

work. (<https://literature.britishcouncil.org/writer/carol-rumens>)

- [An Interview with Rumens](#) — Read a 2006 interview in which Rumens discusses her work and her influences. (https://www.pnreview.co.uk/cgi-bin/subscribe?item_id=2781)
- [Rumens Aloud](#) — Listen to clips of Rumens reading and discussing some of her poetry. (<https://poetryarchive.org/poet/carol-rumens/>)

LITCHARTS ON OTHER CAROL RUMENS POEMS

- [The Emigrée](#)



HOW TO CITE

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